5 DEVOTIONALS ON ZEPHANIAH

He Rejoices over You

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How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. "Digging Deeper" takes you into the context and the language of the original text. "Living It Out" asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

He Rejoices over You
5 devotionals on Zephaniah

Scripture: own translation from the Hebrew (Masoretic Text) by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Verse numbers follow the Hebrew text.

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Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/zefanja/en/

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DAY 1

The Light That Searches the Shadows of the Heart

SCRIPTURE

Zephaniah 1:1–18

[1] The word of the LORD that came to Zephaniah son of Cushi, son of
Gedaliah, son of Amariah, son of Hezekiah, in the days of Josiah son of
Amon, king of Judah.

[2] I will sweep away, sweep away everything
from the face of the ground –
declares the LORD.
[3] I will sweep away man and beast;
I will sweep away the birds of the heavens
and the fish of the sea,
and the stumbling blocks with the wicked.
I will cut off mankind
from the face of the ground –
declares the LORD.
[4] I will stretch out my hand against Judah
and against all the inhabitants of Jerusalem.
I will cut off from this place the remnant of Baal,
the name of the idol-priests together with the priests,
[5] and those who bow down on the rooftops
to the host of the heavens,
and those who bow down and swear to the LORD
and swear by their king,
[6] and those who turn back from following the LORD,
who have not sought the LORD
and have not inquired of him.
[7] Silence before the Lord, the LORD!
For the day of the LORD is near;
for the LORD has prepared a sacrifice,
he has consecrated those he invited.
[8] On the day of the LORD's sacrifice
I will punish the officials and the king's sons
and all who clothe themselves in foreign clothing.
[9] And on that day I will punish
everyone who leaps over the threshold,

those who fill the house of their master
with violence and deceit.
10 On that day – declares the LORD –
a cry will sound from the Fish Gate,
wailing from the Second Quarter,
and a great crash from the hills.
11 Wail, you inhabitants of the Mortar!
For all the people of Canaan are destroyed;
all who weigh out silver are cut off.
12 At that time I will search Jerusalem with lamps,
and I will punish the men
who have thickened on their dregs,
who say in their heart:
"The LORD does no good,
and he does no evil."
13 Their wealth will become plunder
and their houses a desolation.
They will build houses but not live in them;
they will plant vineyards but not drink their wine.
14 Near is the great day of the LORD,
near and hurrying very fast.
Listen! The day of the LORD!
Bitterly the warrior cries out there.
15 A day of rage is that day,
a day of distress and anguish,
a day of wreck and ruin,
a day of darkness and deep gloom,
a day of cloud and thick darkness,
16 a day of ram's horn and battle cry
against the fortified cities
and against the lofty corner towers.
17 I will bring distress on mankind,
and they will walk like the blind,
for they have sinned against the LORD.
Their blood will be poured out like dust,

and their flesh like dung.
18 Neither their silver nor their gold
will be able to rescue them
on the day of the rage of the LORD.
In the fire of his jealousy
the whole earth will be devoured;
for a full end, yes, a terrifying end
he will make of all the inhabitants of the earth.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we begin a five-day journey through the book of Zephaniah – three short chapters that start with the dark "day of the LORD" and end with one of the tenderest promises in the whole Old Testament: *he rejoices over you with a song of joy* (3:17).

The book of Zephaniah opens with a strikingly long family line – four generations back to a certain Hezekiah. This is unique among the prophets, and it immediately gives us a key to Zephaniah's world. Many interpreters take this Hezekiah to be King Hezekiah; the text does not actually call him "king", but why else trace the line back so far? If so, Zephaniah had royal blood in his veins. He was then no outsider criticising the corruption in Jerusalem from a distance; he knew the palace circles from the inside. He prophesied in the reign of King Josiah (about 640–609 BC) – according to many interpreters probably just before Josiah's great religious reform (622/621 BC) got under way.

Judah had just come out of the dark, almost sixty-year reign of King Manasseh (55 years) and his son Amon. Manasseh had filled the temple of the Lord with foreign altars, brought in astrologers and even made his own son pass through the fire (2 Kings 21:3–6). By the time Zephaniah raises his voice, the culture of Jerusalem is soaked in spiritual compromise. The name **Zephaniah** (Hebrew *Tsefanyah* – צְפַנְיָה) means "**The** LORD

has hidden" or "**The LORD treasures / keeps safe**". His name is a prophetic message in itself: in the middle of the coming judgment on the wicked, God will keep his faithful remnant safely hidden.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **"By their king" (*malkam* – מַלְכָּם, v. 5):** God addresses *those who bow down and swear to the* LORD *and swear by their king*. The Hebrew *malkam* means "their king". Some ancient translations (and many modern ones) read *Milkom* here, the name of the Ammonite idol (1 Kings 11:5, 33). Whichever way we read it, the "king" they swear by is hardly the king in Jerusalem – it is another god honoured as king (Milkom or Molech). They swear to the LORD *and* by this other king.
- **"Thickened on their dregs" (*haqqof'im 'al-shimreihem* – הַקֹּפְאִים עַל שְׁמָרֵיהֶם, v. 12):** A picture from winemaking. Wine was left on its lees for a time to gain flavour and strength, but at the right time it had to be poured off into clean vessels (compare Jeremiah 48:11). Wine left too long on its dregs turns thick, syrupy and useless.
- **The day of the LORD (*yom YHWH* – יוֹם יְהוָה, vv. 7, 14–18):** The word "day" tolls through this chapter like a bell – seven times in verses 15–16 alone: *A day of rage is that day, a day of distress and anguish, a day of wreck and ruin, a day of darkness and deep gloom, a day of cloud and thick darkness, a day of ram's horn and battle cry*.
- **"A day of rage" (*yom 'evrah* – יוֹם עֶבְרָה, v. 15):** *'Evrah* is often linked with *'avar*, "to pass over" – anger that overflows, that bursts its banks. In the Latin Bible (the Vulgate) verse 15 begins with the words *Dies irae, dies illa* – "Day of wrath, that day". From these words came the famous medieval hymn *Dies irae* (probably from the thirteenth century; it is often attributed to Thomas of Celano, but that is not certain). For centuries it was sung in the Latin Requiem Mass, and composers such as Mozart and Verdi set it to music. Zephaniah's "day" has echoed through the whole history of the church.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

Chapter 1 unfolds powerful theological truths that lay the foundation for the rest of the book:

1. **Creation undone ("de-creation" in vv. 2–3):** Zephaniah uses language that points straight back to Genesis 1 and to the flood of Genesis 6–7. In Genesis 1 God creates in this order: fish and birds, animals, and finally human beings. In Zephaniah 1:3 the order is reversed: *I will sweep away man and beast; I will sweep away the birds of the heavens and the fish of the sea*. Why? To show that persistent sin and rebellion against the Creator are never just a private matter; they unravel the whole order of creation. When humanity turns its back on God, the whole world suffers.

2. **The danger of syncretism – a divided heart (vv. 4–6):** The people of Jerusalem had not necessarily stopped going to the temple. They still had the name of the LORD (YHWH) on their lips, but at the same time they looked for security to "their king" (or Milkom, the Ammonite god – the reading is debated) and to *the host of the heavens* on their flat rooftops. God has no interest in a shared throne. To serve the Lord half-heartedly while we find our security in the idols of our culture is as offensive to him as open atheism.

3. **Practical atheism and spiritual sluggishness (v. 12):** One of the sharpest images in the Old Testament appears in verse 12. God says: *At that time I will search Jerusalem with lamps, and I will punish the men who have thickened on their dregs*. Like wine left too long on its lees, these people had grown rich, comfortable and spiritually lazy. They said in their hearts: *"The LORD does no good, and he does no evil."* They did not deny God's existence, but his involvement. They lived as if God were a retired spectator who does not care about right or wrong.

4. **The day of the LORD (vv. 7, 14–18):** The people believed that "the day of the LORD" would be a day on which God would destroy all their enemies and lift Judah high (compare Amos 5:18). Zephaniah pulls that false se-

curity out from under them. The day of the LORD begins at his own house (compare 1 Peter 4:17). On that day – fulfilled in the near history when Babylon destroyed Jerusalem in 586 BC, and one day to be fulfilled finally at Christ's return – no silver, gold or economic prosperity can save anyone: *Neither their silver nor their gold will be able to rescue them on the day of the rage of the* LORD (v. 18). "The Mortar" in verse 11 was probably a trading quarter of Jerusalem, where merchants weighed out their silver.

Living It Out

Zephaniah 1 holds up an uncomfortable but life-giving mirror. We no longer burn incense to Baal on our rooftops, but the human heart has not changed at all.

Our greatest temptation in a modern, prosperous or hurried society is the same as Jerusalem's: **spiritual syncretism** and **practical atheism**. With our mouths we confess that we trust the Lord (we "swear to the LORD"), but in practice we bow before the "Milkom" of financial security, status, human approval and self-control. When the bank account is full and our plans run smoothly, we easily become like wine left too long on its dregs: thick, self-satisfied and spiritually asleep.

From Monday to Saturday we often live as if we were saying with them: "*The* LORD *does no good, and he does no evil*" – as if our daily decisions, our integrity at work, the way we speak on social media and the places our thoughts wander lay outside his field of vision. But Zephaniah reminds us that God's loving, holy eyes move with lamps through the darkest corners of Jerusalem – and of our hearts. He does this not because he is a cruel tyrant, but because *the fire of his jealousy* (v. 18) is the zeal of a jealous, loving covenant God who refuses to give his children up to empty idols and spiritual death. As believers in Christ we know that this terrifying "day of rage" and darkness (v. 15) was poured out in full on Jesus at Golgotha, so that we need not be destroyed but can be shaken awake to true life.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If the Lord walked today with a lamp through the hidden rooms of your heart and your daily routine, which "idols" would he find standing beside your worship of him? What do you really trust for your peace and security?
- Are there areas of your life where you have spiritually "thickened on your dregs" – where comfort, routine or disappointment have made you cold and indifferent to God's voice?
- Do you live today aware that God is actively involved in your choices, or do you in practice live as though he were far away and uninvolved?

Prayer

Holy and almighty Lord, today I grow still before you. As Zephaniah 1:7 calls me – "Silence before the Lord, the LORD*!" – I want to silence my own excuses and the noise of my life before your face. Lord, your Word cuts deep and honest. I confess that my heart is so often divided. I sing your praise and confess your name, yet in the same breath I look for my safety in my own abilities, my possessions and the approval of people. Forgive me for the times I live as if you do not see and as if you are not involved in the small decisions of my day.*

Come and search my heart today with your light, Lord. Do not let me grow spiritually sluggish, cold and self-satisfied like wine that has lain too long on its dregs. Shake me awake from my spiritual slumber. Thank you, Lord Jesus, that at Golgotha you bore the full darkness and rage of the day of judgment for me, so that I can be hidden and safe in you. Purify my heart by the fire of your holy love, and teach me to fear and serve you alone with an undivided heart. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 2

Seek the LORD: The Call to Humility and a Place of Shelter

SCRIPTURE

Zephaniah 2:1–7

[1] Gather yourselves together, yes, gather,
O nation without longing,
[2] before the decree is born –
like chaff the day passes by –
before there comes upon you
the burning anger of the LORD,
before there comes upon you
the day of the anger of the LORD.
[3] Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land,
who have done his justice.
Seek righteousness, seek humility;
perhaps you will be hidden
on the day of the anger of the LORD.
[4] For Gaza will be forsaken,
and Ashkelon a desolation;
Ashdod – at noon they will drive her out,
and Ekron will be uprooted.
[5] Woe to the inhabitants of the seacoast,
the nation of the Cherethites!
The word of the LORD is against you,
Canaan, land of the Philistines:
I will make you perish
until there is no inhabitant.
[6] The seacoast will become pastures,
meadows for shepherds
and pens for flocks.
[7] The coast will belong
to the remnant of the house of Judah;
there they will graze,
in the houses of Ashkelon
they will lie down at evening.
For the LORD their God will care for them

and turn back their captivity.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

After sketching the terrifying storm clouds of the "day of the LORD" in chapter 1, Zephaniah changes his tone at the start of chapter 2: from accusation to an urgent, passionate plea. God never announces judgment merely in order to destroy; his warnings are always a gracious invitation to repent before the door finally closes.

In King Josiah's reign Judah was surrounded by old enemies. To the west, along the fertile Mediterranean coast, lay Philistia with its famous five cities, four of which are named here: Gaza, Ashkelon, Ashdod and Ekron. Gath is missing – by this time it had probably already lost its importance. The Philistines (here also called "Cherethites", probably because their ancestors came from the island of Crete and the Aegean world – compare Amos 9:7) had for centuries been a thorn in Israel's flesh and a symbol of military and economic power along the great trade routes to Egypt.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **"Gather yourselves together, yes, gather" (*hitqosheshu waqoshu* – הִתְקוֹשְׁשׁוּ וְקוֹשׁוּ, v. 1):** The verb *qoshesh* is used elsewhere for gathering stubble or straw (Exodus 5:7, 12). Literally, then, something like: *"Gather yourselves up like straw"* – an idiom meaning "Pull yourselves together!", "Come to your senses!" or "Bow down together in humility." And straight after it: *like chaff the day passes by* (v. 2). Time is short: judgment is like a pregnancy about to give birth (*before the decree is born*), and the opportunity for grace blows past as fast as chaff in the wind.

- **"O nation without longing" (*haggoy lo nikhsaf* – הַגּוֹי לֹא נִכְסָף, v. 1):** These words are difficult. *Kasaf* usually means "to long for" (Genesis 31:30; Psalm 84:2 [Hebrew 84:3]) – hence our translation: a nation that no longer longs for God. But the word can also (as in Aramaic) mean "to grow pale": a nation that no longer turns pale with shock at its own sin – a "shameless" nation. Both readings point to the same sickness: a heart that has grown numb.
- **"Humble of the land" (*'anwei ha'arets* – עַנְוֵי הָאָרֶץ, v. 3):** The *'anawim* are those who bow before God in humility, dependence and gentleness – the very people of whom Jesus later says in the Sermon on the Mount: *"Blessed are the humble – they will inherit the earth"* (Matthew 5:5). With them belong the words *tsedeq* – צֶדֶק (righteousness) and *'anawah* – עֲנָוָה (humility).
- **"Perhaps you will be hidden" (*tissateru* – תִּסָּתְרוּ, v. 3):** The verb is *satar*, "to hide". It is a different root from *tsafan*, from which Zephaniah's name comes ("The LORD has hidden"), but the meaning is very close – a quiet play on the prophet's name.
- **Wordplay on the Philistine cities (v. 4):** Zephaniah uses sharp Hebrew wordplay: *Gaza* will be *forsaken* (*'Azzah 'azuvah* – עַזָּה עֲזוּבָה), and *Ekron* will be *uprooted* (*we'Eqron te'aqer* – וְעֶקְרוֹן תֵּעָקֵר).
- **"Care for them" (*yifqedem* – יִפְקְדֵם, v. 7):** This is the verb *paqad* – the same word used in chapter 1 for "punish" (1:8, 9, 12), but here it means to step in with care and compassion.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

This passage unfolds four core truths about God's heart and the way of true repentance:

1. **The call to wake up from shamelessness (vv. 1–2):** Zephaniah addresses Judah as a *nation without longing* – a people that no longer longs for God and no longer turns pale at its own sin. When a culture grows

so used to compromise that its conscience goes numb, spiritual self-examination is the only rescue.

2. **The threefold command to the remnant (v. 3):** Verse 3 is the spiritual heartbeat of the whole book. While most of the people are sluggish and shameless, Zephaniah turns to the *humble of the land*. To them God gives a threefold command: - **Seek the LORD:** not just his blessings or protection, but his person and his presence. - **Seek righteousness (*tsedeq*):** live rightly in your relationships, your business and your daily choices, in line with God's character. - **Seek humility (*'anawah*):** a way of life marked by teachability and total dependence on the Lord.
3. **The promise of shelter – the meaning of Zephaniah's name (v. 3b):** Why should believers seek the LORD? *Perhaps you will be hidden on the day of the anger of the* LORD. The "perhaps" does not suggest that God is fickle; it shows the seriousness of the moment. Grace is never a cheap right we can arrogantly claim; it is a sovereign gift for those who humbly seek shelter in him.
4. **God's sovereignty over the nations and restoration for his people (vv. 4–7):** To encourage believers that it is worth waiting on God, Zephaniah announces the fall of the Philistine cities. Even the mighty Philistine coastal fortresses – Ashdod is driven out *at noon*, probably in the hottest hour of the day, when no one expects an attack – will become quiet pastures for sheep. And finally verse 7 promises: *For the* LORD *their God will care for them and turn back their captivity.*

Living It Out

We live in a time very like Zephaniah 2:1 – a culture that has learned how not to blush any more. We justify our selfishness, our small dishonesties, our bitterness and our spiritual lukewarmness by comparing ourselves with others. We say, "*Everyone does* it," and lose the ability to feel deep sorrow before a holy God.

Zephaniah 2:3 pulls us back to the heart of true discipleship. Notice that Zephaniah calls people who are *already* humble to *seek humility*. Why? Because humility is not a certificate you earn once in your life and hang on the wall. It is a daily choice. Our egos are like weeds; unless we consciously lay our pride down before the cross every morning, self-reliance and pride take over again.

Verses 4 to 7 also show us how deceptive worldly power and security are. To the people of Judah, the rich harbour cities of Philistia looked like the safest, most prosperous places on earth. Yet God shows that what looks like an unshakeable fortress today will be no more than a quiet sheepfold tomorrow. We must not mortgage our hearts to the "Philistia" of worldly success, or live in fear of earthly powers. Our security lies not in how strong our walls are, but in whom we are hidden. In Christ the believer is already safely hidden – *your life is hidden with Christ in God* (Colossians 3:3) – from the final judgment.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Are there areas of your life or your thought world where your conscience has grown numb – things you once regretted but now tolerate without a second thought?
- Zephaniah gives three commands: *Seek the* LORD *... Seek righteousness, seek humility*. Which of the three is most neglected in your daily routine at the moment?
- Which "fortresses" or challenges in your life look at the moment like the mighty cities of Philistia – too big to overcome? How does it change your perspective to know that the Lord cares for you and holds your future in his hands?

Prayer

Gracious Father, thank you that your warnings always flow from a heart of rescue and love. Today I hear your call to come to my senses and to humble myself before you. Lord, keep me from a hard, shameless heart that grows used to sin. Make my conscience soft again and sensitive to the whisper of your Spirit.

I want to obey your Word today: I seek your face, Lord – not only your hand that gives, but your presence. Teach me to seek righteousness in the way I treat the people around me, and grow in me a spirit of true humility and gentleness. Break my pride and my need always to be right or in control.

Thank you that you are my shelter. When the storms of this world rage and the powers of life look as overwhelming as the fortresses of Gaza and Ashkelon, I rest in the knowledge that you reign as sovereign. Thank you, Lord Jesus, that I am safely hidden in you and that you care for me with eyes of compassion. Change my heart, and lead me today on your way of peace. In Jesus' name, Amen.

DAY 3

The Downfall of Pride and the Sole Sovereignty of God

SCRIPTURE

Zephaniah 2:8–15

8 I have heard the reproach of Moab
and the revilings of the Ammonites,
with which they reproached my people
and made themselves great against their territory.
9 Therefore, as I live –
declares the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel –
Moab will become like Sodom,
and the Ammonites like Gomorrah:
a place possessed by nettles, and a salt pit,
and a desolation for ever.
The remnant of my people will plunder them,
and the rest of my nation will inherit them.
10 This they will have for their pride,
because they reproached and made themselves great
against the people of the LORD of hosts.
11 Fearsome will the LORD be against them,
for he will make all the gods of the earth waste away;
and they will bow down to him, each from its place,
all the coastlands of the nations.
12 You too, Cushites –
they are slain by my sword.
13 And he will stretch out his hand against the north
and make Assyria perish,
and he will make Nineveh a desolation,
dry as the wilderness.
14 Herds will lie down in her midst,
every beast of a nation;
the desert owl and the hedgehog
will lodge among her capitals.
A voice will sing in the window,
devastation on the doorstep,
for the cedar work is laid bare.
15 This is the exulting city

that sat secure,
that said in her heart:
"I am, and there is none besides me."
How she has become a desolation,
a lair for wild beasts!
Everyone who passes by her
hisses and shakes his fist.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday (day 2) we saw God's judgment move first to the west, over the coastal cities of the Philistines. In Zephaniah 2:8–15 the prophet completes a full circle of the compass around Judah. He looks first to the **east** (Moab and Ammon), then to the far **south** (Cush, the land south of Egypt along the Nile – ancient Nubia, in present-day Sudan), and finally to the dreaded **north** (Assyria and its capital Nineveh). These four points of the compass are not just a geography lesson; they are a literary and theological way of declaring that the LORD is sovereign King over the whole world. No corner of the earth lies outside his jurisdiction.

Moab and Ammon were Israel's blood relatives, descendants of Abraham's nephew Lot (Genesis 19:36–38). Instead of brotherly loyalty, over the centuries they exploited every crisis in Judah to grab territory and to mock God's people with gloating. The Cushites were known from the Cushite dynasty that had ruled Egypt and the Nile valley until shortly before Zephaniah's time (until about 656 BC). And for generations Nineveh had been the terror of the ancient Near East – an impregnable metropolis with massive walls, palaces fitted out with costly cedar from Lebanon, and a merciless army.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **"Made themselves great" (*wayyagdilu* – וַיַּגְדִּילוּ, v. 8):** The verb (*gadal* in the hiphil) means "to make oneself great, to magnify oneself" – picture someone puffing himself up and sticking out his chest in arrogance.
- **"Their pride" (*ge'onam* – גְּאוֹנָם, v. 10):** The root of their judgment is pride (*ga'on*). There is sharp irony here: Lot, the ancestor of Moab and Ammon, once narrowly escaped from Sodom near the Dead Sea – yet because of their pride their own land will now become like Sodom and Gomorrah: *a place possessed by nettles, and a salt pit, and a desolation for ever* (v. 9).
- **"Make ... waste away" (*razah* – רָזָה, v. 11):** God says he *will make all the gods of the earth waste away* – literally "grow thin"; the word is used of a body that wastes away.
- **"I am, and there is none besides me" (*ani we'afsi 'od* – אֲנִי וְאַפְסִי עוֹד, v. 15):** Nineveh's motto echoes the language with which God describes himself in Isaiah (compare Isaiah 45:5–6, where God says: I am the LORD, and there is no one else); the same words are put in the mouth of Babylon in Isaiah 47:8, 10. Nineveh speaks like one who takes God's place.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God hears the mockery against his people (vv. 8–10):** Notice how personally God takes it: *I have heard the reproach of Moab* (v. 8). God swears by his own life – the highest oath possible (*as I live*, v. 9) – that their fate will be like that of Sodom and Gomorrah. Whoever touches God's children touches the apple of his eye.
2. **The wasting away of idols and worldwide worship (v. 11):** In the middle of these oracles of judgment shines one of the most exalted missionary verses of the Old Testament. How does God make idols "waste away"? By bringing down the mighty nations and economies that relied on those idols, so that everyone can see that these gods are power-

less and empty. Yet the final goal is not mere destruction but conversion: *and they will bow down to him, each from its place, all the coastlands of the nations*. Long before the New Testament, Zephaniah already sees a time when worship will no longer be confined to the temple in Jerusalem, and the most distant nations will kneel before the living God in their own lands (compare John 4:21–24).

3. **From the farthest south to the mighty north (vv. 12–14):** With a single razor-sharp sentence God turns his sword against the south: *You too, Cushites – they are slain by my sword.* Then the focus swings north, to the superpower of the seventh century BC: Assyria. Yet Zephaniah prophesies that this world city will become so deserted that animals and birds will nest among its carved capitals: *the desert owl and the hedgehog will lodge among her capitals* (exactly which creatures are meant is uncertain; older versions have "cormorant" and "bittern" here). Where people once feasted, only the lonely call of owls will echo through the broken windows. (This prophecy was fulfilled in 612 BC, when Nineveh was so thoroughly destroyed that it never again rose as a city; its ruins lay for centuries under mounds of rubble until archaeologists excavated them in the nineteenth century.)
4. **The anatomy of human pride (v. 15):** Why did Nineveh fall? Verse 15 exposes the root sin of every fallen empire and every proud human heart. Nineveh said in her heart: *"I am, and there is none besides me."* Nineveh made herself a god. She believed that her wealth, military might and thick walls made her untouchable. But the city that thought the universe revolved around her ends up a spectacle: *Everyone who passes by her hisses and shakes his fist*.

Living It Out

Zephaniah 2:8–15 speaks directly to two deep struggles in our lives today: **the pain of being treated unjustly**, and **the subtle trap of self-sufficiency**.

First, think of God's words in verse 8: *I have heard* ... Perhaps you find yourself today in a place where you are belittled, mocked or treated unfairly – perhaps because of your faith or your values, or simply by people who try to raise themselves up at your expense, like Moab and Ammon. The temptation is strong to hit back, to grow bitter, or to think that God is silent and absent. This passage assures you that not a single taunt, injustice or tear goes unnoticed by "the LORD of hosts". He hears it. Because he is the Judge who will see justice done in his time, we can lay down the burden of revenge and leave our case safely in his hands.

Second, Nineveh's motto challenges our own hearts: "*I am, and there is none besides me*." Of course we would never say that out loud in church, but we often live it when things are going well. When our finances are stable, our health is strong and our career is flourishing, we build our own little "Nineveh" of false security. We begin to believe that our own cleverness and hard work make us invulnerable.

God has a way of making the "idols" we lean on *waste away* (v. 11) and of laying bare the shiny cedar-panelled façades of our self-confidence (v. 14) – not to destroy us, but to heal us of the illusion that we can save ourselves. True security never lies in how high we build our own walls, but in how low we bow before the living God.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Is there a situation in which you currently feel hurt or despised by the words or actions of others? What does it mean for your peace of mind today to know that the Lord personally says of it: *I have heard* ... (v. 8)?
- Which "gods" or props in your life might the Lord be making waste away at the moment, so that you will turn your full trust and worship back to him alone?
- Where in your life are you operating with a subtle "Nineveh attitude" – an independence that says, "*I've got this under control; I don't need anyone*"?

Prayer

LORD of hosts, King over north, south, east and west – today I bow in reverence before your sole sovereignty. There truly is no one like you. Thank you that you are not a blind or deaf God, but the Father who hears every whisper of pride and every sigh of your children. When I lose heart over injustice or opposition in this world, remind me that you are my Protector and that I do not have to fight my own battles.

Lord, guard my heart from the poison of Moab's gloating and Nineveh's self-exaltation. Forgive me for the times I grow so safe and comfortable in my own plans and prosperity that I live in my heart as if I were the centre of my own universe. Let every false idol and every earthly prop that I trust above you waste away in my life.

I do not want to wait until my earthly certainties collapse before I acknowledge you. I choose today, right here where I am, to bow my knees before you. You alone are my fortress, my rock and my glory. In the mighty name of Jesus, Amen.

DAY 4

From Rebellion to Cleansing: The Birth of a Humble Remnant

SCRIPTURE

Zephaniah 3:1–13

[1] Woe to the rebellious and defiled one,
the oppressing city!
[2] She has not listened to the voice;
she has not accepted discipline.
In the LORD she has not trusted;
to her God she has not drawn near.
[3] Her officials in her midst
are roaring lions;
her judges are wolves at evening
that leave nothing for the morning.
[4] Her prophets are reckless,
men of treachery;
her priests profane what is holy;
they do violence to the instruction.
[5] The LORD in her midst is righteous;
he does no injustice.
Morning by morning he brings his justice to light;
it never fails.
But the unjust knows no shame.
[6] I have cut off nations;
their corner towers are desolate.
I have laid waste their streets,
with no one passing through.
Their cities lie in ruins,
with no one left, with no inhabitant.
[7] I said: "Surely you will fear me,
you will accept discipline" –
then her dwelling would not be cut off,
all that I had appointed for her.
But they rose early
and made all their deeds corrupt.
[8] Therefore wait for me – declares the LORD –
for the day when I rise up for plunder.

For my judgment is to gather nations,
to assemble kingdoms,
to pour out on them my fury,
all my burning anger;
for in the fire of my jealousy
the whole earth will be devoured.
9 For then I will change the lip of the peoples
into a pure lip,
so that all of them call on the name of the LORD
and serve him shoulder to shoulder.
10 From beyond the rivers of Cush
my worshippers, the daughter of my dispersed ones,
will bring my offering.
11 On that day you will not be put to shame
for all your deeds
by which you rebelled against me;
for then I will remove from your midst
those who exult in your pride,
and you will no longer be haughty
on my holy mountain.
12 I will leave in your midst
a people poor and lowly,
and they will shelter in the name of the LORD.
13 The remnant of Israel
will do no injustice and speak no lie,
and no deceitful tongue
will be found in their mouth.
For they will graze and lie down,
and no one will make them afraid.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of chapter 2 (day 3) the listeners in Judah probably cheered when Zephaniah announced the downfall of hated, arrogant Nineveh. But at the start of chapter 3 the prophet makes a brilliant rhetorical turn: he pronounces a new "Woe" over a filthy, rebellious and oppressive city, without naming it straight away. The people of Jerusalem would at first have assumed he was still speaking about Nineveh – until verses 2 and 4 took their breath away: "*to her God she has not drawn near … her priests profane what is holy*". The corrupt city in his sights is no longer pagan Nineveh; it is Jerusalem herself!

This passage takes us from the deepest diagnosis of human stubbornness to one of the most beautiful promises of spiritual renewal and cleansing in the whole Old Testament. First the city's spiritual deafness is laid bare (vv. 1–2); then her corrupt leaders are set against the faithful LORD in her midst (vv. 3–5); next comes the fire of God's judgment on the nations (vv. 6–8); and finally the promise of a pure lip for the peoples and a humble remnant in Zion (vv. 9–13).

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Rebellious, defiled and oppressing (*mor'ah wenig'alah … hayyonah* – מֹרְאָה וְנֶגְאָלָה … הַיּוֹנָה):** Jerusalem is called *rebellious* (*mor'ah* – defiant and stubborn), *defiled* (*nig'alah* – morally and ritually stained), and the city *that oppresses* (*hayyonah* – exploiting the weak).
- **Discipline (*musar* – מוּסָר):** Loving correction – not punishment meant to destroy, but a father's training (cf. Hebrews 12:5–11).
- **Reckless (*pochazim* – פּוֹחֲזִים):** The prophets are "*reckless*" – unstable and shallow, like boiling water that bubbles over and has no weight (the same root is used in Genesis 49:4 of water boiling over).

- **A pure lip (*safah berurah* – שְׂפָה בְרוּרָה):** The Hebrew says literally "*a pure lip*"; *safah* can also mean "speech, language". At Babel (Genesis 11:1, 7, 9) the whole earth had one *safah*, and there the LORD confused their *safah*.
- **Shoulder to shoulder (*shekhem 'echad* – שְׁכֶם אֶחָד):** Literally "with one shoulder" – like oxen pulling shoulder to shoulder under the same yoke.
- **A people poor and lowly (*'am 'ani wadal* – עַם עָנִי וָדָל):** *'Ani* means "poor, afflicted" (the same root as *me'annayikh* – מְעַנַּיִךְ, "who afflict you", 3:19). Here it means not only people who are trampled down, but people who are poor in spirit (Matthew 5:3) – healed of self-exaltation.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The fourfold spiritual deafness (vv. 1–2):** Verse 2 shows exactly how spiritual decline works, in four steps that follow one another: - She has not **listened** to the voice (deaf to God's word). - She has not **accepted discipline** (loving correction). - In the LORD she has not **trusted** (no surrender in faith). - To her God she has not **drawn near** (prayer and close fellowship die away).

When we stop listening to God's voice and push away his correction, our trust and our prayer life inevitably dry up. 2. **Corrupt leaders against God's faithful morning light (vv. 3–5):** Judah's whole leadership has turned into beasts of prey. The civil leaders (officials and judges) tear the people apart like roaring lions and like "*wolves at evening that leave nothing for the morning*" – gnawing even the bones by daybreak. The spiritual leaders (prophets and priests) are *reckless* and bend God's instruction for their own gain. Against this dark human betrayal verse 5 stands like a mountain: "*The* LORD *in her midst is righteous … Morning by morning he brings his justice to light*". While corrupt judges in the city gates do injustice in the morning, God's righteousness rises every morning as reliably as the sun. Yet the people harden their consciences ("*they rose early and*

made all their deeds corrupt", v. 7) and refuse to learn from the history of other fallen nations. 3. **The reversal of Babel: a pure lip for the nations (vv. 8–10):** The fire of God's judgment (v. 8) is not the last word; it is a furnace that refines. In verse 9 a miracle happens: "*For then I will change the lip of the peoples into a pure lip*". Many interpreters see here a direct reversal of the **Tower of Babel** (Genesis 11). At Babel humanity joined forces in its pride, and God confused their "lip" (language) and scattered them. Now God promises that through his saving work he will cleanse the lips of the peoples from idolatry and cursing, so that they call on the name of the LORD and serve him "*shoulder to shoulder*". Verse 10 adds that from beyond the rivers of Cush (the land south of Egypt along the Nile, for Israel the farthest edge of Africa) his worshippers will bring him an offering – probably his own scattered people coming home, though some interpreters think of people from the nations themselves. This prophecy finds its New Testament fulfilment on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2) and in the worldwide church of Christ. 4. **The humble remnant that shelters in God (vv. 11–13):** What does a person renewed by God's grace look like? God removes "*those who exult in your pride*" and leaves "*a people poor and lowly*". This does not mean that God wants his children to be downtrodden, but that they have been healed of self-exaltation. Because they "*shelter in the name of the* LORD", their guilt and shame are taken away (v. 11), their words are honest and free of deceit, and they enjoy deep rest: like a flock that grazes and lies down safely, with no enemy to make them afraid (v. 13).

Living It Out

Zephaniah 3:1–13 confronts us with the most dangerous trap for religious people: **seeing other people's sins while staying blind to our own spiritual deafness.** It is easy to point at the "Nineveh" of our secular world and complain about how bad things are out there, while the four signs of verse 2 quietly move into our own hearts: we no longer listen attentively to the

word, we become defensive when the Spirit (or a fellow believer) corrects us, we trust in our own plans, and we no longer draw near to God in quiet, honest prayer.

Look at the sharp contrast between verse 5 and verse 7. God comes to us **morning by morning**, faithful with his light, his grace and his justice (cf. Lamentations 3:22–23). But the rebellious person **rises early** to pursue his own wrong ways with zeal! How we begin our mornings – where our first thoughts, our first loyalty and our first energy go – often shows who is really king in our life.

And yet the message of this passage is overwhelmingly hopeful. We cannot cleanse ourselves of our own pride or our own impure lips. That is why God says in verses 9 and 11: "**I will ...**" God himself performs the heart surgery. Through the cross of Jesus Christ the shame of our past is wiped out ("*On that day you will not be put to shame for all your deeds*", v. 11). He gives us a new language – lips that no longer need to lie, flatter or tear down to protect ourselves – and he invites us to serve shoulder to shoulder with other believers in his kingdom, safe and set free from fear.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Look again at the four steps in verse 2: *listen to the voice*, *accept discipline*, *trust in the* LORD, *and draw near to him*. With which of these four are you currently experiencing the most resistance or sluggishness in your walk with the Lord?
- What do the words that have crossed your lips this past week (at home, at work or in traffic) say about the state of your heart? Do you need the Lord to give you a "pure lip" today?
- Are you still trying to build your identity on how strong, impressive and independent you appear – or have you discovered the freedom of belonging to the humble people, "poor and lowly", who find all their security and rest in the name of the LORD alone?

Prayer

Righteous and faithful Father, just as the morning sun rises every morning without fail, so your faithfulness and righteousness dawn anew over my life every day. Today I bow before you and confess that I am so often like Jerusalem: quick to see the faults of others, but slow to listen to your voice and to accept your loving discipline. Forgive me for the times I have hardened my heart, leaned on my own understanding and lived far from you.

Lord, I thank you that your grace is stronger than my rebellion. Thank you for the promise that you cleanse what I have defiled. Touch my mouth and my heart today and give me pure lips – lips free of deceit, bitterness and pride, that call on your name in truth. I lay down my pride and the burden of my past shame at the foot of Jesus' cross.

Make me gentle and humble in spirit, Lord. Teach me to serve shoulder to shoulder in unity with your children, and let my heart graze and rest today in the safe shadow of your name, where no fear can make me afraid. In the precious name of Jesus, Amen.

DAY 5

The God Who Rejoices over You with a Song of Love

SCRIPTURE

Zephaniah 3:14–20

14 Sing for joy, Daughter Zion!
Shout aloud, Israel!
Be glad and exult with all your heart,
Daughter Jerusalem!
15 The LORD has taken away the judgments against you;
he has turned away your enemy.
The King of Israel, the LORD, is in your midst;
you will fear evil no more.
16 On that day it will be said to Jerusalem:
"Do not fear, Zion!
Do not let your hands hang limp!
17 The LORD your God is in your midst,
a warrior who saves.
He beams with gladness over you;
he is silent in his love;
he rejoices over you with a song of joy."
18 Those who grieve far from the appointed feast I have gathered;
they were from you –
a burden on her, a reproach.
19 Look, at that time I will deal
with all who afflict you.
I will save the lame
and assemble the outcast,
and I will make them a praise and a name
in all the earth where they were put to shame.
20 At that time I will bring you home,
at the time when I assemble you;
for I will make you a name and a praise
among all the peoples of the earth,
when I turn back your captivity
before your eyes, says the LORD.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Few books in the Bible undergo such a breathtaking shift as Zephaniah. The book began in chapter 1:2 with thunder, darkness and the looming fire of judgment: "*I will sweep away, sweep away everything from the face of the ground – declares the* LORD." Yet this same short prophecy ends in chapter 3:14–20 with one of the most tender, intimate and exuberant love songs in all of Scripture. Once the furnace of God's discipline has burned away pride and idolatry, a refined bride remains – and the heavenly Bridegroom bursts into song over her!

This closing passage is the spiritual summit of Zephaniah – and the last day of our five-day journey through the book. Verse 17 also gives this series its title: "*he rejoices over you*". The passage unfolds three wonderful truths about God's saving grace: the acquittal and the presence of the King (vv. 14–16), the Warrior who sings over his people (v. 17), and the restoration of the broken and scattered (vv. 18–20).

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Four words for joy (v. 14 – שִׂמְחִי וְעָלְזִי ... הָרִיעוּ ... רַנִּי):** Verse 14 piles up four different Hebrew words for joy: *ranan* (sing for joy), *rua'* (shout aloud), *samach* (be glad) and *'alaz* (exult with all your heart).
- **The judgments taken away (*hesir* YHWH *mishpatayikh* – הֵסִיר יְהוָה מִשְׁפָּטַיִךְ):** "*The* LORD *has taken away the judgments against you*" – the sentence has been cancelled and the charge sheet wiped clean.
- **In your midst (*beqirbekh* – בְּקִרְבֵּךְ):** Literally "within you". "*The King of Israel, the* LORD, *is in your midst*" (v. 15), and again in verse 17: "*The* LORD *your God is in your midst*".
- **Limp hands (v. 16):** "*Do not let your hands hang limp!*" – a Hebrew idiom for discouragement, exhaustion and despair.

- **A warrior who saves (*gibbor yoshia'* – גִּבּוֹר יוֹשִׁיעַ):** He is no passive spectator but a mighty Warrior who fights and wins on behalf of his defenceless children.
- **He beams with gladness over you (*yasis 'alayikh besimchah* – יָשִׂישׂ עָלַיִךְ בְּשִׂמְחָה):** Isaiah 62:5 uses the same verb for a bridegroom's joy over his bride.
- **He is silent in his love (*yacharish be'ahavato* – יַחֲרִישׁ בְּאַהֲבָתוֹ):** The phrase is hard. Literally it says "he is silent (keeps still) in his love", and that is how we translate it. Some read it as "he quiets you by his love"; the ancient Greek translation (the Septuagint) has "he will renew you" – apparently the translators read a *d* instead of an *r* (*yachadish*, "he makes new").
- **He rejoices over you with a song of joy (*yagil 'alayikh berinnah* – יָגִיל עָלַיִךְ בְּרִנָּה):** The word *gil* is sometimes linked with "spinning around" – dancing for joy – though that derivation is not certain; in any case it is exuberant joy, accompanied by a loud song of jubilation (*rinnah*). *Rinnah* comes from the same root as *ranan* in verse 14: Zion is called to sing – and then she hears that God sings over *her*.
- **The lame and the outcast (*hatsole'ah ... hanniddachah* – הַצֹּלֵעָה ... הַנִּדָּחָה):** Shepherd's language for sheep that are hurt, limping and scattered by beasts of prey (cf. Micah 4:6–7).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The acquittal and the presence of the King (vv. 14–16):** Why can a city that only shortly before stood under heavy judgment now celebrate so exuberantly? Verse 15 gives the twofold reason: - **Justification:** *"The* LORD *has taken away the judgments against you"*. The sentence has been cancelled and the charge sheet wiped clean. - **Immanuel presence:** *"The King of Israel, the* LORD*, is in your midst"*. That is why their hands no longer need to "hang limp". Where God's judgment has been taken away and his presence moves in, fear gives way.

2. **The Warrior who sings and is silent in his love (v. 17):** Zephaniah 3:17 has sometimes been called "the John 3:16 of the Old Testament". Every phrase paints a facet of God's heart: - **A warrior who saves:** God is a Warrior who fights for his children and wins. - **He beams with gladness over you:** God does not merely put up with his redeemed children with a frown on his brow; he takes intense delight in them. - **He is silent in his love:** What a profound expression! Just as a mother holds a crying child to her breast and grows still over it in deep, wordless tenderness, or as a bridegroom gazes at his bride, speechless with wonder, so God grows still in his love for us. It also means that he is *silent* about our former sins – he never brings them up again to accuse us (cf. v. 15: he has taken away the judgments). - **He rejoices over you with a song of joy:** The Creator of the universe sings and rejoices over his rescued children!
3. **Restoration for the broken and the outcast (vv. 18–20):** God's festive song does not leave out the weak; on the contrary, his heart beats precisely for those who have fallen behind along the way. Look at whom he gathers in verses 18–19: - *Those who grieve far from the appointed feast* – cut off from the feasts at the temple, as later in the exile. - *The lame* and *the outcast* – where they once bore the mockery and shame of the world, God promises a complete reversal ("*I will make you a name and a praise*"). The book ends with the same promise with which the restoration began in chapter 2:7: "*when I turn back your captivity before your eyes, says the* LORD."

Living It Out

How do you picture God's face when you think of him in prayer today? Many believers live their whole spiritual life under the impression that God does love them because he "has to", but that he is actually always a little disappointed, impatient or frustrated with them. We think of him with a frown on his face.

Zephaniah 3:14–20 smashes that distorted picture of God. For everyone who has found shelter in Jesus Christ, the final "day of the LORD" has already taken place at Golgotha. On the cross Jesus took our judgments on himself and disarmed our spiritual enemies – sin, death and the accuser (Colossians 2:14–15). That is why God can look at you today, not through the lens of your failures, but through the perfect righteousness of his Son.

When the Holy Spirit lives in you, the King is *in your midst* (v. 15). And what does he do? He **is silent in his love** – he does not bring up your confessed sins of yesterday against you again. Even more astonishing: he **sings over you**! When your hands hang limp today from discouragement, exhaustion or self-reproach, Zephaniah reminds you that you do not have to try to climb up to God in your own strength. The mighty Warrior has already come down to you. He picks up the "limping" and broken parts of your life, turns your shame into a testimony of his grace, and invites you to become still and listen to the song of salvation he is singing over your life.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do you truly believe, deep down, that God beams with *gladness* over you and rejoices over you with a song of joy – or do you still live as though you have to earn his approval? What keeps you from accepting his joy over you?
- In which area of your life are your hands hanging limp with discouragement right now (v. 16)? How does knowing that the Lord is present in the middle of that situation as *"a warrior who saves"* change your courage today?
- Are there places of old shame, brokenness or "limping" in your past for which you still accuse yourself, while God has long since chosen to be silent about them – *"he is silent in his love"* – and to turn them into a testimony of praise?

Prayer

Lord my God, my King and my Redeemer, words fail me before the wonder of your grace in Zephaniah 3! Having travelled through the depths of your holy judgment, I stand today in wonder before the cross of Jesus Christ, where you took away all the judgments against me and blotted out the record of my debt.

Father, forgive me for so often thinking of you as a distant, disappointed Judge, while you reveal yourself as the mighty Warrior who lives within me and rejoices over me with a song of joy. When my hands hang limp today with weariness and worry, strengthen me with the knowledge that you are with me. Teach my heart to grow still in your love – that love which forgives my past and is silent about my sins.

Today I bring to you every broken, limping and discouraged part of my life, my Shepherd. Gather what has been scattered in me, heal what is hurting, and turn my shame into a song to your glory. Today I choose to exult in you with all my heart, because I am safely hidden and dearly loved in you. In the wonderful name of Jesus Christ, Amen.

The whole book of Zephaniah

The complete text of Zephaniah in the translation used in these devotionals.

Chapter 1

[1] The word of the LORD that came to Zephaniah son of Cushi, son of Gedaliah,
son of Amariah, son of Hezekiah, in the days of Josiah son of Amon, king of
Judah.

[2] I will sweep away, sweep away everything
from the face of the ground –
declares the LORD.
[3] I will sweep away man and beast;
I will sweep away the birds of the heavens
and the fish of the sea,
and the stumbling blocks with the wicked.
I will cut off mankind
from the face of the ground –
declares the LORD.
[4] I will stretch out my hand against Judah
and against all the inhabitants of Jerusalem.
I will cut off from this place the remnant of Baal,
the name of the idol-priests together with the priests,
[5] and those who bow down on the rooftops
to the host of the heavens,
and those who bow down and swear to the LORD
and swear by their king,
[6] and those who turn back from following the LORD,
who have not sought the LORD
and have not inquired of him.
[7] Silence before the Lord, the LORD!
For the day of the LORD is near;
for the LORD has prepared a sacrifice,
he has consecrated those he invited.
[8] On the day of the LORD's sacrifice

I will punish the officials and the king's sons
and all who clothe themselves in foreign clothing.
9 And on that day I will punish
everyone who leaps over the threshold,
those who fill the house of their master
with violence and deceit.
10 On that day – declares the LORD –
a cry will sound from the Fish Gate,
wailing from the Second Quarter,
and a great crash from the hills.
11 Wail, you inhabitants of the Mortar!
For all the people of Canaan are destroyed;
all who weigh out silver are cut off.
12 At that time I will search Jerusalem with lamps,
and I will punish the men
who have thickened on their dregs,
who say in their heart:
"The LORD does no good,
and he does no evil."
13 Their wealth will become plunder
and their houses a desolation.
They will build houses but not live in them;
they will plant vineyards but not drink their wine.
14 Near is the great day of the LORD,
near and hurrying very fast.
Listen! The day of the LORD!
Bitterly the warrior cries out there.
15 A day of rage is that day,
a day of distress and anguish,
a day of wreck and ruin,
a day of darkness and deep gloom,
a day of cloud and thick darkness,
16 a day of ram's horn and battle cry
against the fortified cities
and against the lofty corner towers.

17 I will bring distress on mankind,
and they will walk like the blind,
for they have sinned against the LORD.
Their blood will be poured out like dust,
and their flesh like dung.
18 Neither their silver nor their gold
will be able to rescue them
on the day of the rage of the LORD.
In the fire of his jealousy
the whole earth will be devoured;
for a full end, yes, a terrifying end
he will make of all the inhabitants of the earth.

Chapter 2

1 Gather yourselves together, yes, gather,
O nation without longing,
2 before the decree is born –
like chaff the day passes by –
before there comes upon you
the burning anger of the LORD,
before there comes upon you
the day of the anger of the LORD.
3 Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land,
who have done his justice.
Seek righteousness, seek humility;
perhaps you will be hidden
on the day of the anger of the LORD.
4 For Gaza will be forsaken,
and Ashkelon a desolation;
Ashdod – at noon they will drive her out,
and Ekron will be uprooted.
5 Woe to the inhabitants of the seacoast,
the nation of the Cherethites!
The word of the LORD is against you,
Canaan, land of the Philistines:

I will make you perish
until there is no inhabitant.
6 The seacoast will become pastures,
meadows for shepherds
and pens for flocks.
7 The coast will belong
to the remnant of the house of Judah;
there they will graze,
in the houses of Ashkelon
they will lie down at evening.
For the LORD their God will care for them
and turn back their captivity.
8 I have heard the reproach of Moab
and the revilings of the Ammonites,
with which they reproached my people
and made themselves great against their territory.
9 Therefore, as I live –
declares the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel –
Moab will become like Sodom,
and the Ammonites like Gomorrah:
a place possessed by nettles, and a salt pit,
and a desolation for ever.
The remnant of my people will plunder them,
and the rest of my nation will inherit them.
10 This they will have for their pride,
because they reproached and made themselves great
against the people of the LORD of hosts.
11 Fearsome will the LORD be against them,
for he will make all the gods of the earth waste away;
and they will bow down to him, each from its place,
all the coastlands of the nations.
12 You too, Cushites –
they are slain by my sword.
13 And he will stretch out his hand against the north
and make Assyria perish,

and he will make Nineveh a desolation,
dry as the wilderness.
14 Herds will lie down in her midst,
every beast of a nation;
the desert owl and the hedgehog
will lodge among her capitals.
A voice will sing in the window,
devastation on the doorstep,
for the cedar work is laid bare.
15 This is the exulting city
that sat secure,
that said in her heart:
"I am, and there is none besides me."
How she has become a desolation,
a lair for wild beasts!
Everyone who passes by her
hisses and shakes his fist.

Chapter 3

1 Woe to the rebellious and defiled one,
the oppressing city!
2 She has not listened to the voice;
she has not accepted discipline.
In the LORD she has not trusted;
to her God she has not drawn near.
3 Her officials in her midst
are roaring lions;
her judges are wolves at evening
that leave nothing for the morning.
4 Her prophets are reckless,
men of treachery;
her priests profane what is holy;
they do violence to the instruction.
5 The LORD in her midst is righteous;
he does no injustice.

Morning by morning he brings his justice to light;
it never fails.
But the unjust knows no shame.
6 I have cut off nations;
their corner towers are desolate.
I have laid waste their streets,
with no one passing through.
Their cities lie in ruins,
with no one left, with no inhabitant.
7 I said: "Surely you will fear me,
you will accept discipline" –
then her dwelling would not be cut off,
all that I had appointed for her.
But they rose early
and made all their deeds corrupt.
8 Therefore wait for me – declares the LORD –
for the day when I rise up for plunder.
For my judgment is to gather nations,
to assemble kingdoms,
to pour out on them my fury,
all my burning anger;
for in the fire of my jealousy
the whole earth will be devoured.
9 For then I will change the lip of the peoples
into a pure lip,
so that all of them call on the name of the LORD
and serve him shoulder to shoulder.
10 From beyond the rivers of Cush
my worshippers, the daughter of my dispersed ones,
will bring my offering.
11 On that day you will not be put to shame
for all your deeds
by which you rebelled against me;
for then I will remove from your midst
those who exult in your pride,

and you will no longer be haughty
on my holy mountain.
12 I will leave in your midst
a people poor and lowly,
and they will shelter in the name of the LORD.
13 The remnant of Israel
will do no injustice and speak no lie,
and no deceitful tongue
will be found in their mouth.
For they will graze and lie down,
and no one will make them afraid.
14 Sing for joy, Daughter Zion!
Shout aloud, Israel!
Be glad and exult with all your heart,
Daughter Jerusalem!
15 The LORD has taken away the judgments against you;
he has turned away your enemy.
The King of Israel, the LORD, is in your midst;
you will fear evil no more.
16 On that day it will be said to Jerusalem:
"Do not fear, Zion!
Do not let your hands hang limp!
17 The LORD your God is in your midst,
a warrior who saves.
He beams with gladness over you;
he is silent in his love;
he rejoices over you with a song of joy."
18 Those who grieve far from the appointed feast I have gathered;
they were from you –
a burden on her, a reproach.
19 Look, at that time I will deal
with all who afflict you.
I will save the lame
and assemble the outcast,
and I will make them a praise and a name

in all the earth where they were put to shame.
20 At that time I will bring you home,
at the time when I assemble you;
for I will make you a name and a praise
among all the peoples of the earth,
when I turn back your captivity
before your eyes, says the LORD.